

Chapter 162-1

Investor. Joining a production with funding.

These two terms together made it hard not to let one's imagination run wild.

Zhao Xuning set down her half-finished beer and stared straight at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi: "?"

It seemed like a century-long stare.

Then Zhao Xuning turned her head and calmly watched TV.

Liang Shi: "?"

A few seconds later, Liang Shi gave a light cough: "What?"

Zhao Xuning's voice was flat: "Nothing."

But her usually expressionless face carried a hint of barely suppressed amusement.

Liang Shi couldn't help herself. "What? Are you doubting the truthfulness of what I said?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "No."

"Then what's with that expression?" Liang Shi took a big gulp of beer.

Zhao Xuning looked surprised and casually raised an eyebrow: "Hm? Is something wrong?"

"Three parts mockery, four parts cold indifference—you know what I mean?"¹ Liang Shi glared at her. "Right now you're not just similar to that person—you're practically identical."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The slightly upturned corners of her mouth suddenly stiffened, looking very awkward.

"Even more alike now," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning: ".....Go away."

Liang Shi stared at the message on her phone again, then said to her very seriously: "Don't not believe me. This is how it is for newcomers entering the entertainment industry. It's not like Sister Ying, who had backing and resources from the start. For small fry like us, when those big shots see we have some looks, they just... you know what I mean."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"Power crushes people." Liang Shi scrolled through her agent's messages, then closed them, still thinking about whether to go or not.

Zhao Xuning was still staring at her.

Liang Shi got angry: "You don't believe me, do you?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "I believe you."

But her face showed no sign of actually believing it.

Liang Shi was already thinking about whether to bring pepper spray tomorrow. Just as she was about to place an order on the shopping app, a thought suddenly struck her—

"Zhao Xuning, do you think I'm not attractive enough, so no one would try to use unspoken rules on me?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

She crushed the empty beer can in her hand, stood up, and returned to her room, leaving Liang Shi with a back that said "figure it out yourself."

Liang Shi casually grabbed a throw pillow and hurled it at her retreating figure, but it only hit the already-closed door.

"Zhao Xuning." As Liang Shi got up to retrieve the pillow from her doorway, she muttered a complaint: "Is it that hard to compliment someone?"

Zhao Xuning, who was in her room looking at Liang Shi's Weibo: "....."

"Sooner or later you're going to suffer because of that personality of yours," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning's finger on the screen suddenly paused.

Those words sounded so familiar.

Even the tone was similar.

Back then, Shen Hui had also complained to her: "Is it that hard to compliment someone?"

It was just that when Shen Hui said it, there was more coquettishness and grievance than when Liang Shi said it.

Shen Hui's tone back then was much softer than Liang Shi's.

Shen Hui had said to her: "Your mouth is so pretty—would it kill you to say some nice things?"

Zhao Xuning often felt helpless with her.

She wasn't good at saying pretty words, nor could she do pretty things.

Back then, she was young and proud, full of vigor, always thinking it wasn't a big deal.

But looking back now, it seemed like it was.

She really had suffered quite a bit because of this personality.

Zhao Xuning lowered her eyes, looked up Liang Shi's company, and then made a phone call to a friend.

"Yeah, it's me," Zhao Xuning said. "I heard Huayi's upper management changed?"

The other person was startled: "Yeah, it was jointly acquired by Minghui Jewelry and Zhenghe Group."

"Minghui Jewelry?" Zhao Xuning was surprised.

"Yeah, that's Xu Qingzhu. You should know her, right?" the other person said. "Didn't she take over from her dad a while back? She suddenly reconciled with Haiwei Jewelry, and Su Zhe has been helping her with all his might. During that time, everyone was saying there's no smoke without fire after all these years."

"Xu Qingzhu is the daughter of Sheng Qinglin and Su Yao. Someone even saw her out and about with Su Yao." The other person summarized the situation concisely: "Now she's somehow connected with the Lu family in the capital, and acquired Huayi in less than a week."

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning said, "Thanks."

The other person was curious: "But why are you asking about this?"

"My cousin signed with that company," Zhao Xuning said. "Just checking."

"Sister Ying, huh," the other person laughed. "I can't believe Sister Ying didn't start her own company."

"She's too lazy." Zhao Xuning chatted with her for a few more lines, then found an excuse to hang up.

She had thought Liang Shi had really encountered the entertainment industry's unspoken rules.

Now she realized Liang Shi was overthinking it.

However, in the depths of the night, Zhao Xuning had a dream that startled her awake.

Drenched in cold sweat.

She raised her hand to cover her eyes. There were water droplets on her eyelashes.

She reached over to grab her phone and looked—1:20 AM.

Right when people were in deep sleep.

The house was completely quiet, without a single sound.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Three parts mockery, four parts cold indifference"** (三分譏笑四分涼薄): This is a famous phrase from the Chinese TV drama "Mo Shang Sang" (陌上桑) or similar period dramas, often used to describe a character's aloof, slightly contemptuous demeanor. It's become an internet meme to describe someone with a cold, mocking expression. The fact that Liang Shi compares Zhao Xuning to "that person" suggests she's referencing a well-known fictional character with this trademark expression.